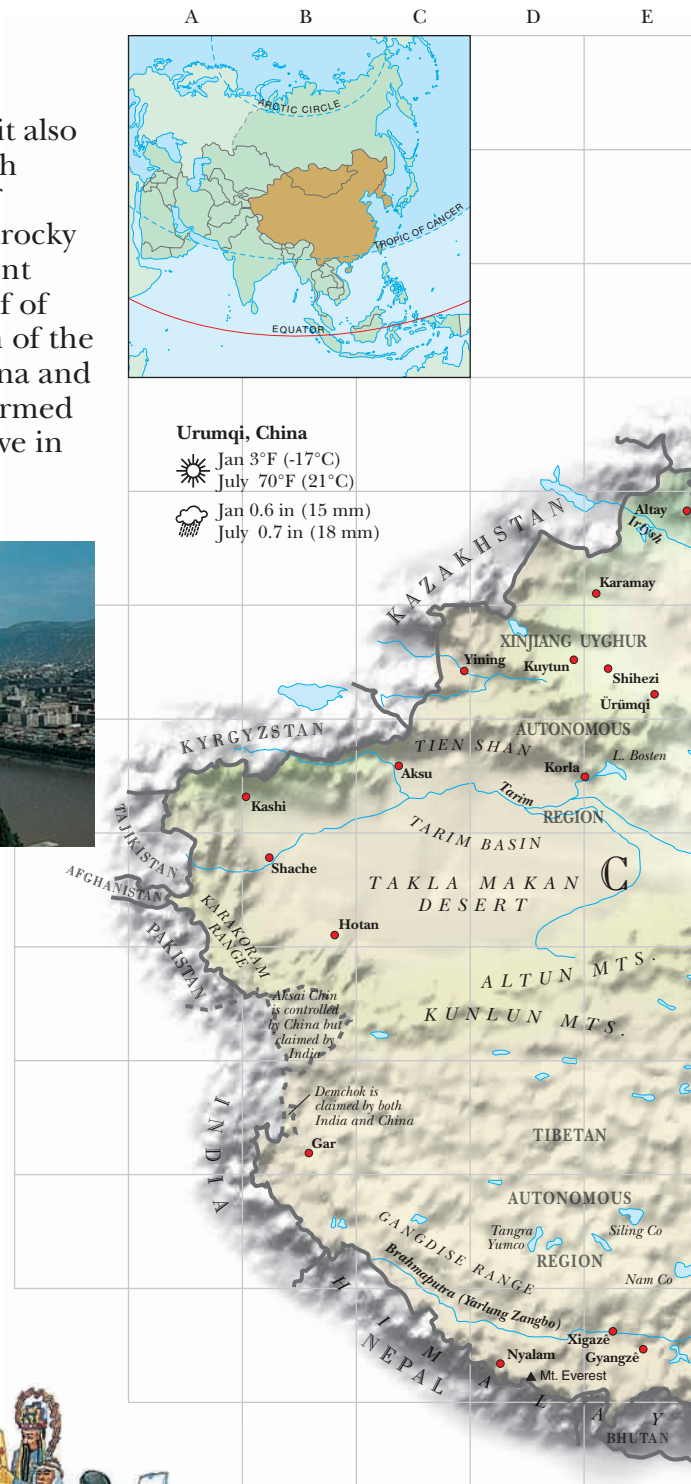
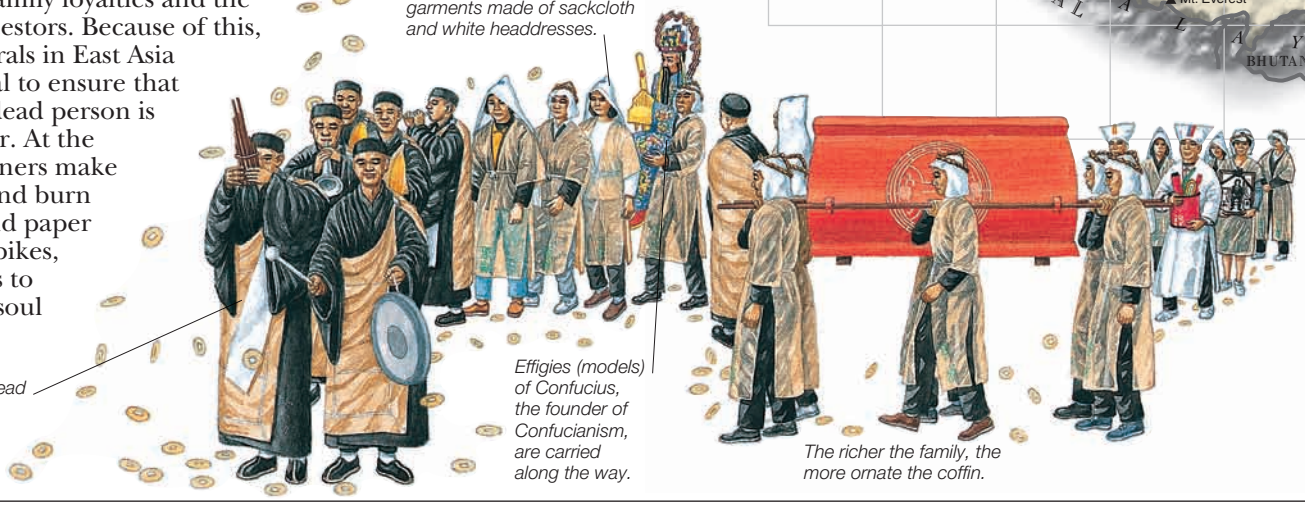
EAST ASIA

EAST ASIA IS DOMINATED by the vast country of China, but it also includes the windswept plains of Mongolia, North and South Korea, and the fertile island of Taiwan. China itself is full of contrasts. In the west, high ranges of mountains tower over rocky valleys and semidesert plains. Tibet, a previously independent country occupied by China since 1950, is known as the "roof of the world" because it is so high above sea level. In the north of the country is the harsh and empty Gobi Desert. In eastern China and North and South Korea, river valleys and flood plains are farmed intensively, providing food for the millions of people who live in the cities on or near the coast.



THE YELLOW RIVER
The Yellow River, or Huang He, is one of the world's most destructive rivers. It has flooded the surrounding land many times, causing enormous loss of life. For this reason, the river is known as "China's Sorrow." As it slowly glides eastward through central China, it erodes huge amounts of fertile loess (fine soil) from the land, which stains the river yellow.

THE GREAT WALL
Snaking across northern China, from the Yellow Sea in the east to the deserts of central Asia in the west, is one of the technological wonders of the ancient world. Much of the Great Wall was built in the 1400s to protect Chinese farmers from invasion by nomads from Mongolia. At almost 4,000 miles (6,400 km) long, it is the world's longest structure, and is a popular tourist destination.

ANCESTOR WORSHIP

One of the main ideas of Confucianism, the ancient religion of China, is the importance of family loyalties and the honoring of ancestors. Because of this, traditional funerals in East Asia follow a set ritual to ensure that the soul of the dead person is well provided for. At the graveside, mourners make food offerings and burn paper money and paper models of cars, bikes, and other goods to accompany the soul to heaven.